



Samia Suluhu Hassan

(SAH-mee-ah soo-LOO-hoo hah-SAHN)

President
United Republic of Tanzania

Addressed as: **Your Excellency** | Office held since: **March 2021**

Samia Suluhu Hassan, often known as "Mama Samia," is a leader whose instinct for reform runs alongside her intolerance of dissent when her authority is challenged.

▣ Opening Space

After President John Magufuli's sudden death in 2021, Samia showed her reform-minded pragmatism and investor-friendly inclinations, restoring Tanzania's diplomatic standing, reversing COVID-19 denialism, lifting media bans, and restarting negotiations with multinational firms.

▣ Closing Space

In the runup to her 2025 reelection, Samia purged the ruling party, harassed opposition leaders, restricted political activity, interfered with elections, and violently cracked down on protesters, leading to hundreds of deaths.

Samia often discusses how gender shapes the way others assess her. At Magufuli's funeral, she directly addressed those who doubted that a woman could lead. In March 2022, she boasted that she had performed "better than most of her male counterparts in Tanzania and Africa in general".

WHY THEY MATTER

Samia is repositioning Tanzania as open to foreign investment in its energy, mining, and transportation sectors as long as the country's broader interests are respected and direct benefits for Tanzanians are secured.

▣ Rebuilding Investor Confidence

She is determined to complete projects of national importance to unlock jobs, investment and sustainable prosperity. Her government has offered tax incentives and ramped up engagement with multinational and regional energy firms.

▣ Safeguarding Tanzania's Future

Samia wants major foreign projects, but she is acutely sensitive to the argument that Tanzania might surrender excessive revenue, resources or legal control. In July 2026, she instructed her lawyers to protect national resources and intervene before contracts become burdens.

Samia's organizing project is Vision 2050—a \$1 trillion economy and 8.5 million jobs—and she has told officials she wants a lasting legacy before she retires in 2030.

MEETING WITH THEM

Despite her self-described soft-spoken and calm nature, she is often probing for potential concessions and not above delivering a tough message to counterparts.

▣ **Gratitude First, Ask Second**

Samia often credits her interlocutors for their contributions before pressing for more. When she met with Vice President Kamala Harris in 2023, she thanked the United States for PEPFAR and its malaria initiative—then made a request for an extension of the Africa Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA) to 2030.

▣ **“Give-Or-Take” Compromises**

In 2022, Samia explained her approach to negotiations as “give-or-take, so both sides should embrace fluidity in order to achieve the intended goal...safeguarding national interests while ensuring investors obtain commercial returns”.

*Her humor is dry and self-aware. She joked about sending lions and elephants to Central Park, teased filmmaker Peter Greenberg about his favorite animal, and told him he had tortured her with repetitive voiceover recording for his documentary *The Royal Tour*.*

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **Chinese Rail Deal**

China Civil Engineering Construction Corp. in July secured a \$2.7 billion contract for a 506-kilometer railway in Tanzania. The line will connect Tabora and Kigoma, forming part of a network linking Dar es Salaam to Burundi, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and Zambia.

▣ **More Crackdowns**

Tanzanian police in early July arrested 130 people for “inciting criminal acts” as part of efforts to contain dissent after a ban on all political rallies. The protesters had planned to gather on the July 7 public holiday to call for democratic reforms and justice for people killed in election violence last year.

▣ **Dangote’s Investments**

Africa’s richest man, Aliko Dangote, in late June said he plans to make major investment in ports, power, and roads in Tanzania, as part of his plans to expand amid a surge in global fuel and fertilizer costs.

▣ **U.S. Senate Review**

U.S. Senators Jeanne Shaheen (D-NH) and Ted Cruz (R-TX) in May introduced the bipartisan Reassessing the United States-Tanzania Bilateral Relationship Act. This legislation requires a comprehensive review of the U.S.-Tanzania relationship, an indication of growing U.S.-Tanzanian tension following controversial national elections on October 29, 2025.

NETWORK

Samia is balancing ties with Washington, Beijing, Moscow, and the Gulf to ensure that no single partner sets her terms, especially in the aftermath of the controversial 2025 poll.

She chose Russia for her first state visit after her second inauguration, and continues to deepen ties with China, exemplified by the revitalization of the Tanzania–Zambia Railway (TAZARA). Even amid worsening political relations, Samia met with U.S. diplomats to discuss energy and critical mineral deals.

Samia appears aware that her control over the ruling CCM is contested, spurring her to purge rivals, initiate regular cabinet changes, and promote family members.

She initially leaned on former President Jakaya Kikwete and other old guard politicians to weaken Magufuli’s faction within the CCM. She eventually sidelined many of her erstwhile allies, temporarily reappointed some of Magufuli’s associates, and named her daughter and son-in-law as deputy minister and minister, respectively.

CONTROVERSIES

Samia’s largely positive image has been tainted by the repression that surrounded her 2025 election and scandals surrounding several business transactions.

▪ Election Crises

The leading opposition figures were barred from participating in the polls, and one was charged with treason. Her election win, with 97.66 percent of the vote, was marked by violence and an internet blackout. Human Rights Watch and Amnesty have documented arbitrary arrests, enforced disappearances, and torture allegations since 2024.

▪ Opaque Deals

Samia’s 2023 agreement with Dubai-based DP World to manage and operate key berths at the Port of Dar es Salaam has been criticized for its indefinite timeline and broad terms that risked surrendering control over a vital transport asset. Similarly, she has come under fire for moving over 100,000 Maasai pastoralists from Ngorongoro Conservation Area and Loliondo to convert the land into game reserves and safari hunting concessions.

In March 2026, Tanzania’s anti-corruption authority reported deficiencies in 913 of 1,864 monitored public projects and opened investigations into 66 projects. The projects reviewed were worth approximately \$5.41 billion.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- ▣ **President**, United Republic of Tanzania (2021 to present)
- ▣ **Vice-President**, United Republic of Tanzania (2015 to 2021)
- ▣ **Vice Chairperson**, Constituent Assembly (2014)
- ▣ **Minister of State for Union Affairs**, Vice-President's Office (2010 to 2015)
- ▣ **Member of Parliament**, Makunduchi Constituency (2010 to 2015)
- ▣ **Minister for Tourism, Trade and Investment**, Government of Zanzibar (2005 to 2010)
- ▣ **Minister for Labor, Gender Development and Children**, Government of Zanzibar (2000 to 2005)
- ▣ **Member**, Zanzibar House of Representatives (2000 to 2010)
- ▣ **Project officer**, UN World Food Program and local NGOs (1988 to 2000)

BIO

Samia's background as Zanzibari and Tanzania's first female leader has shaped her approach to politics and her personal life. Born on January 27, 1960 in Kizimkazi village in South Unguja, Zanzibar, she is a schoolteacher's daughter who has traveled widely across Tanzania, Pakistan, India, and the UK for her education.

▣ **The Only Woman**

When she was the only senior woman in the Zanzibar cabinet, she found male colleagues were initially dismissive, but she stood her ground until they accepted her. She later described herself as a highly efficient worker: "I was so hard-working that the bosses would come to me if they wanted something done."

▣ **In Her Free Time**

Samia enjoys Taarab, a popular style of orchestral music blending African, Arabic, and Indian influences. In 2022, she said that she listens to Taarab not only during leisure time but also as background music while working through official files. Some of her favorite activities are people-watching in Zanzibar's Stone Town and spending time with her grandchildren.

Samia has been married to Hafidh Ameir, a retired agricultural officer, since 1978; they have four children and she is a grandmother. A practicing Sunni Muslim, she tells clerics that the strength of religion is in the heart and that no faith overrides the constitution. Samia speaks Kiswahili and English.

NOTES